



Free the Sheep

By Anna Kirschberg

Illustrated by James Keiaho



Book Summary

This fictional story depicts two farm dogs and a flock of sheep on a farm.

The flock of sheep beg to the farm dogs to release them from their paddock so that they can escape to the valley and find more grass. What will the farm dogs decide to do? Will they free the sheep? Vibrant illustrations depict and help the text explain the story information about each page.

This book is the third book in the 12 book series of Sound Families (Fiction) decodable readers which covers long vowels (/ai/ /ee/ /igh/ /oa/ /oo/ and /y-oo/). There are two book titles for each sound. Within each reader, alternative spellings are provided (graphemes) for the target sound (phoneme).

The book title “Free the Sheep” covers the long vowel sound family of /ee/, where alternative spellings are provided for /ee/: /i/, /e/, /y/, /ey/, /ie/, /ea/.

Skills and Strategies

Children can identify the target sound in the text quickly as they have been highlighted in bold in the text and then compare the spelling across the sound family. Other words included are decodable at the phase level as well as common exception words in accordance to the decodable progression.

Phase 5.5 - Sound Families

/ai/	/ee/	/igh/	/oa/	/oo/	/y-oo/
/r/	/n/	/m/	/ch/	/k/	/sh/
/j/	/v/	/u/	/e/	/i/	/s/
/zh/ /z/	/ar/	/or/	/ur/	/air/	/ear/

The book title “Free the Sheep” covers the long vowel sound family of /ee/, where alternative spellings are provided for /ee/: /i/, /e/, /y/, /ey/, /ie/, /ea/.

This book also supports other key reading strategies:

- Recognising the relationship between words and illustrations.
- Building fluency skills.
- Vocabulary and word study.

This book also supports key comprehension strategies:

- Predicting the meanings of new or unfamiliar words from the context of the story;
- Recognising the relationship between letters and their sound families;
- Summarising the main ideas of the story.

Introducing the Text

Open up the discussion about the front cover illustration and make connections with the children’s prior knowledge. Prompt discussions by using the vocabulary in the book.

What does the title of the story tell you about the front cover image?

Describe the characters and setting on the front cover.

Look at the sound family notation /ee/ on the front cover and identify where this features in the book title.

Look at the phonemes highlighted on the front inner cover. Review the sound family table together.

Reading the Text

Pages 2 and 3 – Before reading begins, discuss the setting of the story and make predictions about what the story is about. Review the target sound family listed in the front inner cover and identify the highlighted words in the book text as examples of the sound family.

Pages 4 and 5 – Here, the farm dogs discuss with the sheep the reasons why they cannot let them out of their paddock.

Pages 6 and 7 – Continue to review the target sound /ee/ and identify the word examples which are related to this sound family. Can you hear the similarities in the sounds and see the differences in spellings within the words? Can you think of other example words which contain these sounds.

Page 8 – The illustration on the final page shows the sheep running off to the valley. The farm dogs discuss how Farmer James will react. The dogs follow the sheep to round them back up to the paddock. Can you identify any words with the target sound family, within the text on the final page?

Children can now read the book independently and fluently. At the end of the story, go over the text and illustrations again and discuss what is happening on each page.

Revisit the target sound family /ee/ being taught in this title.

Revisiting the Text

As a group, refer back at the phoneme table in the front inner cover and identify the words in the story that have been highlighted. The target phoneme has been highlighted in the text as it can be represented by various different graphemes or spelling patterns, representing a sound family.

Following Up

Use the BM for this story, the students can learn more about the long vowel Sound Family for /ee/.